engagements. The SED Party bulletin also served as a source of information about his political activities and travels.

Western newspaper reports and diplomats provided the BND with additional scraps of information, while agents amassed a wealth of anecdotal evidence. Although BND reports were cobbled together chronologically without evaluation or analysis, they create a diverse picture of Honecker's political activities and colourful trivialities. The information was divided into different categories: spa stays, vacations, official trips, award ceremonies, personal and political activities. As mentioned earlier, the so-called 'Honi' file also detailed his hunting habits, which proved a constant source of fascination for counterintelligence officials. Although brief, one cable even laid out details of Honecker buying ski boots for his grandson and confusing two pairs, resulting in him gift-wrapping two left-footed boots in a Christmas box. Interestingly, the BND devoted considerable attention to Sonja and her son, Roberto. One note records that Roberto looked like the 'younger version of Margot' (in brackets: 'Actually very pretty'). There was also intelligence about Honecker's taste, including a note detailing how during a vacation in Baabe, the First Secretary took a fancy to a green velvet armchair in a room utilised for his office. According to the report, he found it so beautiful that he wanted it for his Berlin office. His request was granted. Curiously though, the BND files omit to mention that 1974 ended with the death of Honecker's sister Frieda, leaving just Gertrud, who still lived in the parental home in the Saarland, and Erich as the only surviving members of the original family.

For Erich Honecker, one of the great successes of 1974 was pushing through a constitutional amendment that finally abandoned the concept of German nationhood and redefined the German Democratic Republic as a 'socialist state of workers and farmers'. The changes took effect on 7 October, the twenty-fifth anniversary of the foundation of the GDR.

Honecker explained the reasons for the changes by saying that the Constitution must consider the 'new qualitative progress in shaping the developed socialist society in the communist future'. Turning to the new Constitution preamble, he asserted that it was doing justice to the historic change. 'Today the GDR is an internationally recognised sovereign state